

Episode 42: Connected Through Mizuki Shigeru Originals – Remembering *Akuma-kun*

I'm working hard not to miss my manuscript deadline this week! (explosion)

Man, March! Tokyo has gotten warm all at once. It still gets pretty cold from midnight through morning, but during the day it's nice and toasty. On my way to work, I find myself wanting to sit on a park bench and bask in the sun (laugh).

Starting today, I'm saying "farewell" to my down coat. I'll send it to the cleaners and store it away in the back of the closet until next season (laugh).

Such is March.

Hakaba Kitaro, currently airing to great acclaim, finished creating all character colours last week, so my work is mostly done. What remains is checking the portions that colour directors are handling for episodes #10 and #11, plus checking the main story rushes.

For broadcasts, we have 3 episodes left, with episode 9 "Johnny in the Fog" airing Thursday night this week in the Kanto region.

Well then.

Recently, when I look around at *Hakaba Kitaro*-related reactions online, I inevitably come across the opinion "Wouldn't this staff do *Akuma-kun*?" Unfortunately, there are no such plans at the moment (bitter laugh), but huh? *Akuma-kun*? I worked on that before.

So, the story of *Akuma-kun*.

Series composition by Koyama Takao, series director Sato Jun'ichi, character design by Suzuki Kin'ichiro, art design by Mukuo Takashi. It started broadcasting in April 1989, as the follow-up to *Saint Seiya* (聖闘士星矢).

Ah yes, that's right—come to think of it, this was also based on original work by Mizuki Shigeru. Supernatural stories really feel like Mizuki-san originals, don't they? Well, those of us making it (at least me...!) weren't really conscious of the original work...

Speaking of *Akuma-kun*, when I was still a child, there was a live-action TV version. I think it was still black and white? That was incredibly scary (laugh), but I watched it every week without fail. When Akuma-kun blew his ocarina and smoke rose from Mephisto's head, it felt weirdly realistic in a way, and that was somehow terrifying. When I got to work on the anime version, I remember that scary TV show was still in my mind.

The anime *Akuma-kun* made Mephisto into "the Second," a round, child-like character, with overall cute character designs aimed at children. Hyakume was cute too (laugh). In exchange, the demons that appeared as guests in each episode were pretty solid characters, I think...

In this *Akuma-kun* series, I handled the colouring settings for the main characters and the main guest demons of each episode, plus the colour direction and inspection for the opening and ending, and the colour direction for the first few episodes after the series started. Oh, and I also participated in the first theatrical version.

In the series, there were Akuma-kun's companions called the "Twelve Apostles," and they would all appear together on screen quite often, which was pretty tough. Naturally, finishing was still analogue back then. With animation cels and cel paint finishing, when you had detailed drawings on one animation frame, it was really hard. There were quite a lot of cuts like that. After all, it was Toei with their frame count restrictions (bitter laugh). To reduce the number of animation frames, they'd cram everything onto the

same animation drawing. It was a real nuisance for the finishing department. Well, that still happens now (bitter laugh).

And then those characters would all get high contrast or evening colour changes at once. One colour change meant making all 12 versions, which was quite exasperating.

These Twelve Apostles were summoned by Akuma-kun blowing his ocarina from a magic circle, and at this time, there would be special colouring with footlight-style shadows from the glowing magic circle as a light source, and this was great. With pink to purple high-contrast tones, the backgrounds and cels finished in exactly my favourite colour usage, and I was very happy—shameless self-praise (laugh).

Also, the tarot cards that appeared in the main story. I got to do the colour direction for these too. I bought real tarot cards with my own money and studied them earnestly, which brings back memories (laugh).

Until then I had been working on *Saint Seiya* continuously. Actually, *Saint Seiya* was a story that developed in a very narrow scope, and the characters that appeared were actually limited and few. Most of the time, it was just one-on-one fighting (laugh). In that respect, *Akuma-kun* was basically a story that developed within the daily life of modern Japan, so many different things appeared, making it a very educational production for me.

It really made me realise that to do colour direction, you have to know about all sorts of things! Not just things that actually exist in reality, but also the work of expanding your imagination to create something—first you need to firmly understand things that actually exist in the world and that you can touch, or you can't give persuasive power to the "colours" you create by building up imagination (bitter laugh).

That philosophy still flows at the foundation of my thinking today, and that was the production that taught me such things.

Oh, as an aside, the opening song for this *Akuma-kun*—when you sing it at karaoke, everyone gets excited! It turns into a big chorus! (laugh)

This *Akuma-kun*—wasn't it released on DVD? With *Hakaba Kitaro* as a catalyst, I'm hoping this *Akuma-kun* might also get the DVD treatment (laugh).

(08.03.04)